

SYMBOLISM

An object or image representing a bigger idea



1 What is it?

Symbolism (SIM-buh-liz-um)

Symbolism is when an **object, colour or image** represents a bigger idea, emotion or theme beyond its literal meaning.

object = bigger idea

2 See it in action

Colour symbolism

A white dove often symbolises peace or hope.

Object symbolism

A broken mirror can symbolise a fractured sense of self.

Seasonal symbolism

Winter often symbolises death, endings, or difficulty.

In "Lord of the Flies"

The conch shell symbolises order and civilisation.



Mfalme says...

Watch for an object that keeps **reappearing** throughout a text — repetition is usually the biggest clue that something is symbolic.

FUN FACT

Some symbols are shared across almost every culture (like light = hope, or snakes = danger), while others are invented fresh by a single writer for just one story.

3 Why writers use it

Symbolism helps writers: add deeper layers of meaning without stating them directly, let a reader "discover" a theme through their own interpretation, and connect a simple object to a huge, complex idea.

A good symbol can appear again and again throughout a text — each time it reappears, it can build on and deepen its meaning.

4 Where you'll spot it

Flags & logos

Colours and images are chosen deliberately to represent a country, team or brand's identity.

Film & TV

Recurring objects (a red door, a broken watch) often carry meaning that builds across an entire series.



Watch out!

A symbol always needs **textual evidence** to support it — don't just claim something is symbolic because you think it might be; point to how the text builds that meaning.



Look here!

Always back up a symbolism claim with **evidence from the text** — what does the writer actually do or say around that object to build its meaning?

5 Quick recap

Object represents a
bigger idea

Adds deeper meaning

Can build across a whole
text



You got this!

Try picking an everyday object and brainstorming three different ideas it could symbolise — a key could mean freedom, secrets, or opportunity.